Framing the Future

Veteran gallerist Sreejith CN opens up on treating art as a fixed asset, spotting future M.F. Husains and the rising dominance of Delhi's gallery scene

By **RIDHI KALE**

Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

"A line is a dot that went for a walk."

When the Swiss-German Bauhaus master Paul Klee wrote that definitive sentence, he was mapping the absolute genesis of visual art. Decades later, that very philosophy anchors New Delhi's competitive gallery landscape. "Our name had to be unique, so when a friend brought up Klee's quote, it clicked," recalls Sreejith CN, founder of Gallery Dotwalk. Today, that walking dot has found its stride in Delhi's elite cultural ecosystem. In fact, the gallery's strategic relocation from Gurgaon to the creative hotbeds of South Delhi marks a decisive shift in capturing the Capital's collector base.

Learning the Ropes

With 26 years of market navigation under his belt, Sreejith's entry into this world was entirely serendipitous. Arriving in Delhi from Kerala in the late 1990s without formal art training, he entered the trade alongside his elder brother, selling decorative pieces. He quickly recognised the potential of the market, leaning into socialisation to gain access to rare private holdings of Indian masters. "I learned that if you are consistent in any sector, growth is one hundred per cent," he notes.

Small Wonders

The gallery's current exhibition, *The Architecture of the Void: Lines on a Postcolonial Skeleton*, challenges the contemporary obsession with scale. Featuring 43 tightly curated pieces that focus on smaller paperworks by non-living modern masters, with veteran artist Jogen Chowdhury standing as the sole living exception. "If you go for a large canvas, it will easily be a multi-crore piece," explains Sreejith. "We chose to showcase these small formats from the gallery's private collection and our well-wishers to show how disciplined collecting over 15 years builds an extraordinary portfolio." The pricing of the pieces included in the show reflects this balance between historical gravity and accessibility. The entry point sits at ₹8 lakh for an intimate paperwork by senior modernist Sadanand Bakre. At the apex of the exhibition is a highly coveted piece by Jogen Chowdhury, valued anywhere between ₹60 and ₹70 lakh.

Invest in These

For the uninitiated youth looking to enter the art market, Sreejith recommends "one-artwork-per-year" acquisition rule. He cautions younger buyers against exhausting their capital on established modern masters, steering them instead toward high-potential contemporary names. "In the early 60s and 70s, legendary figures like M.F. Husain and Ram Kumar were highly affordable," observes Sreejith. To unearth these future masters, Sreejith points to a promising stable of younger artists gaining sharp international responses, including Priyaranjan Purkait, Chandrashekar Koteshwar and Mehak Garg. For collectors looking for established contemporary names poised to become the next modern masters, he recommends Sujith SN, Mahesh Baliga and T. Venkanna. Sreejith also encourages his clients to interrogate galleries before parting with hard-earned capital. "I tell my clients to ask me why they should buy this piece."

Looking ahead, Gallery Dotwalk's planning a solo show for veteran filmmaker and artist K.M. Madhusudhanan, followed by a group exhibition in Hyderabad. Sreejith proves that a single dot, when allowed to take a walk, can open up infinite possibilities.